

SATION

The suicide bomb attack on Bhutto is the latest evidence of the alarming spread of extremism across the country



THE MODERATE FACE: (Above) Benazir visits an attack victim in a hospital; (Left) tribesmen during an anti-government rally in Miranshah

143 dead, 545 injured in Karachi blast on Oct 18



Over 100 dead in July siege of Lal Masjid



tacks throughout Pakistan, according to Interior Ministry figures—most of them in the north-west of the country. They have all been linked in one way or other with Al Qaeda militants since the phenomenon itself was introduced in Pakistan after the American attacks on Afghanistan post 9/11. The ongoing army operation against militants in the north-western tribal areas bordering Afghanistan and the recent bloody crackdown on those holed up in Islamabad's Lal Masjid has triggered most of the recent attacks. That the attack on the PPP rally resulted in the largest number of casualties was simply because of the massive number of people present in the procession at that time.

But beyond the suicide attacks, which—until October 18—had mostly targeted the army, law enforcement personnel, ministers or Western installations like the US consulate in Karachi, another sinister wave of extremism is sweeping north Pakistan. Dubbed as "Talibanisation" of the north-west, it has seen attacks on innocuous targets like video and music shops—"spreading obscenity"—and even barbers who, according to the militants, "oppose Islamic law" by trimming beards. Beginning in the Federally Administered Tribal Areas, this wave of obscurantism has now spread to parts of the North-West Frontier Province such as Malakand, Dir, Swat and Swabi. Militants from Islamabad's Lal Masjid had also attempted to enforce a similar code against music and video shops as well as massage salons in the federal capital before they were "taken out". Despite being condemned by the Government and many parts of civil society, attacks have become so commonplace that many businesses have either shut shop or their owners have switched to other trades.

Militancy has also been aided by a perception that the Pakistan Army is engaged in a war against its own people at the behest of the United States. More than 900 army men have lost their lives in the fight against militants in tribal areas—particularly Waziristan, where Mehsud and others are said to be hiding—and there seems to be no end to the warfare. American exhortation to Musharraf "to do more" has only fuelled the feeling in these

ars alone mostly in the lawless tribal zones of north-west.